Relative pronouns: who, which, where

Goal: By the end of this lesson, you will be able to join two sentences with the relative pronouns **who**, **which** and **where**, and to write a definition such as "A museum is a building where works of art are kept."

The idea in two lines: A relative pronoun replaces a repeated noun and links two ideas in one sentence. **Who** is for people, **which** for things and animals, and **where** for places (it means "in that place").

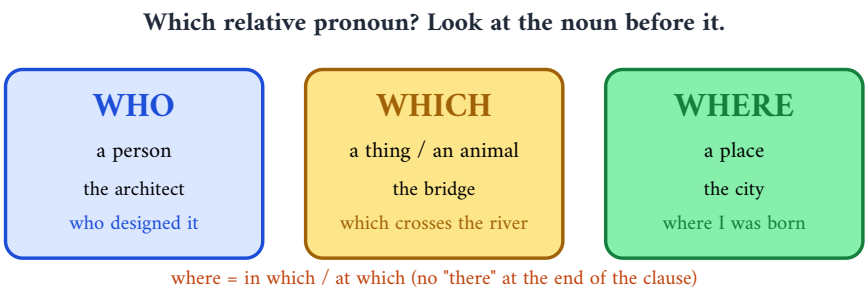


Figure 1: Choosing who, which or where according to the noun that comes before the relative clause.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. A **relative clause** starts with a **relative pronoun** and comes right after the noun it describes.
2. **Who** refers to people: *Ibn Khaldun was a historian who wrote about North Africa.*
3. **Which** refers to things and animals: *The Sphinx is a statue which has the body of a lion.*
4. **Where** refers to places: *Tipaza is a town where you can see Roman ruins.*
5. After **who** and **which**, do not repeat *he, she, it*: *a guide who speaks English*, not "who he speaks".
6. After **where**, the clause has its own subject: *the museum where **we** saw the mosaics*. Do not add *there* at the end.
7. **That** can replace *who* or *which* (*the man that built it*), but never *where*.

🟢 Examples

1. Join: *Gustave Eiffel was an engineer. He designed the Eiffel Tower.* **Answer:** Gustave Eiffel was an engineer who designed the Eiffel Tower. **Explanation:** "engineer" is a person, so *who* replaces "He".
2. Join: *The Taj Mahal is a mausoleum. It is made of white marble.* **Answer:** The Taj Mahal is a mausoleum which is made of white marble. **Explanation:** a thing, so *which* replaces "It".
3. Join: *Ghardaia is a town. Many tourists visit the old market there.* **Answer:** Ghardaia is a town where many tourists visit the old market. **Explanation:** a place; "there" disappears because *where* already means "in that place".

🟠 Common BEM mistakes

- Using *which* for people: "the king which built the palace" instead of *who*.
- Repeating the subject: "a monument which *it* attracts visitors". Delete *it*.
- Using *where* when the place is the subject of the verb: "a mosque where is very old". Write *a mosque which is very old*.
- Keeping *there* after *where*: "the city where I live there".

🟡 Quick review

- who = people; which = things, animals; where = places.
- The relative pronoun comes directly after the noun.
- No he / she / it after who or which; no there after where.
- If the place is the subject of the verb, use which, not where.
- BEM definitions: "A … is a person who / a thing which / a place where …".

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